

"Horseback Riding" - A Stand-Up Bit About Language

Name: _____

Date: _____

The bit (paraphrased, not quoted in full)

A stand-up comedian points out that "horseback riding" – the standard American English term – is, in his view, an unnecessarily descriptive phrase. His argument: you've obviously seen a horse before, so where else would you expect to ride one? He imagines someone who takes this logic to its extreme and jokes about trying to "**horse-front-ride**" instead. As a punchline, he compares "let's go horseback riding" to an equally absurd invented phrase for driving a car: "**car-inside-drive**." Nobody says that – you'd just say "let's go for a drive" – so, his argument goes, why does horse riding need the extra word?

The real language point behind the joke

This is actually a genuine, documented difference between British and American English: - **British English:** riding, horse riding, go riding - **American English:** horseback riding

Neither is "more correct" – it's simply a regional difference, the same kind you've already looked at with accents in the horse riding and tennis videos. The comedian's joke works precisely *because* the American version sounds redundant to anyone used to just saying "riding."

Discussion: Can you think of other things English says two ways depending on the country, where one version has an "extra" word the other doesn't? (If the group is stuck: *fall/autumn, apartment/flat, soccer/football, sneakers/trainers* are different words entirely rather than one being more "descriptive" – but it's worth letting them try before you help.)

Creative writing/speaking extension: invent your own

Using the same pattern as "horse-front-ride" and "car-inside-drive" – take a normal action and describe it in a needlessly literal, overly descriptive way, as if you were explaining it to someone who'd never heard of it.

Examples to model it: - Dribbling a basketball "**hand-bounce-throw**" - Hitting a tennis forehand "**arm-swing-hit**" - Watching TV "**eye-screen-look**"

In pairs, students invent 3-4 of their own for sports or everyday actions, then present them to the class, who have to guess what real action is being described. Good vocabulary recycling from the whole sports unit, dressed up as a game rather than a review exercise.

Written exercises (10 min)

A. British vs American - matching

Match each British word to its American equivalent.

British: riding · autumn · flat · football · trainers

American (mixed up): A. sneakers B. horseback riding C. soccer D. apartment E. fall

B. Invent your own - writing frame

Fill in the table with your own "needlessly literal" version of each action.

Real action	Your invented phrase
Dribbling a basketball	
Serving in tennis	
Mounting a horse	
(your own choice)	

Model answers: hand-bounce-throw (dribbling) · arm-swing-hit-over-net (serving) · leg-swing-up-sit (mounting).

C. Short writing

Write 3-4 sentences explaining, in plain English, why "horseback riding" sounds redundant to a British speaker but not to an American one.

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About this activity

Standalone activity, ~15-20 min – for B1-B2 students, pairs well with the sports idioms pieces

The bit (paraphrased, not quoted in full)

(Play the actual clip for this bit rather than reading it out – it's a genuine comedy routine and works much better performed than paraphrased.)

C. Short writing

Kept the actual joke paraphrased rather than transcribed word-for-word here, since it's someone else's stand-up material – better to just play the clip itself for the real performance, and use this as the framework around it.

A. British vs American - matching

1. riding-B, autumn-E, flat-D, football-C, trainers-A